

THE WARD-STONE

An unofficial Baldur's Gate 3 spec script

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A personal portfolio writing sample

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An unofficial *Baldur's Gate 3* spec script. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Larian Studios or Wizards of the Coast. All writing is original; no in-game dialogue is reproduced.

Scene · Act 1 · a wayshrine in **Greenharrow**, a wilderness hamlet · the party led by **Shadowheart**, with **Lae'zel**, **Karlach**, and **Gale**. An old warded relic, an innocent keeper, and four companions who each want something different from it.

THE SHRINE

Narrator: *As you enter the annex, you smell strong scents of beeswax and tea in the air. As you look around, you notice at its heart, on a low ancient pedestal of river-stone worn smooth rests a ward-stone the size of a heart — silver veins faintly aglow, set apart and tended like the holy artifact it is. You hold still, and there is a low hum beneath the silver, like a held breath. You frown as you notice the artifact call to you with a faint but familiar sensation that you once thought forgotten. Have you been here before?*

The old halfling beams at you the way people do when they have been alone with their pride too long.

Prue: Visitors! Sit, sit — kettle's just sung. Come to see her, have you? (*patting the ward-stone, familiar as a cat*) Everyone does, sooner or later. Mind — plenty on the road of late, but they don't stop in like you have. Pilgrims, I tell myself. (*a small shrug*) Though pilgrims usually want their tea.

Shadowheart — (*choose one*)

1. "So. Who guards this artifact at night?"
2. "We're only passing through. What is it?"
3. **[Religion]** "That's consecrated work. Moon-blessed — and set to *hold* something, unless I'm mistaken."
4. (*Say nothing. Let her talk.*)

Option 2 CHOSEN: Shadowheart: "We're only passing through. What is it?"

Prue: The Greenharrow ward-stone, dearie — set by the Moonmaiden's chosen when I was a girl in plaits. She keeps the bad-hearted things off — the wolves, aye, but *worse* things too: the ones that come in the dark, and in the dreams. (*no less cheerful for the weight of it*) There's four hamlets and the whole refugee road under her hand now — hundreds of souls sleeping easy who've never once had to know why. Without her? (*a comfortable certainty*)

Oh, a great many would die, dearie. That's why she's never left her stand, bless her, not once in my sixty years. My Aldous — Selûne keep him — used to say the whole valley slept inside her cupped hand.

Narrator: *Refugees on the road from two days past had spoken of Greenharrow the way drowning men speak of driftwood. And there is something beneath the silver hum of the thing — a weight that your eyes cannot perceive clearly but the hair on the back of your neck insists is there.*

Shadowheart: *(circling the pedestal, half to herself — talking)* She talks to it like it can hear her. My— *(a beat; the catch arrives late)* ...Some faiths would envy that. The uncomplicated kind. *(under her breath)* If only it wasn't the Moonmaiden.

Gale: *(head tilting, Gale catches a scent — then bravado falls away, because this is real)* That hum. Do you feel it? Old-weave — unlike any ordinary village warding, dense as the old empires' craft. *(he steps closer, and his voice drops)* No — I can feel *past* the warding. There's something *bound* under there. This isn't just a ward-stone — it's a *lid*. *(he looks up at you (Shadowheart), and there is no doubt in it, only dread)* I couldn't possibly tell you precisely what it holds down. I *can* tell you that a warding this deliberate is only ever built over something you'd give a very great deal to keep asleep — I believe lifting it could have devastating consequences, and not ones that stop at Greenharrow's fences.

Narrator: *Something in the floor seems to answer him — a pressure through the soles of your boots, there and gone before you can be sure of it. Whatever Gale has surmised is down there, some older part of you has already felt the edge of it too. It feels older than anything you have felt before. But also... wounded, the air carries a somewhat gnawing feeling of dread with one certain emotion: it wants out.*

Prue: *(delighted that Gale is impressed, hearing none of the dread)* Ooh, "old-weave"! Aldous never had a word so grand for her. Just "our girl." *(warming up, oblivious)* And she does more than keep raiders off, mind. No whispers in the night, no mind-mists. Turns aside what creeps inside one's head. *(moves to set up her tea set)*

Lae'zel: *(the pause is one heartbeat too long)* It bars intrusion of the *mind*. *(and there it is; the want, dressed as doctrine)* This is no hearth-charm, no peasants' comfort. It could be a shield against the ghaik, left to rot on a pedestal. We should requisition it.

Karlach: Whoa — no. Nope. *Absolutely* not, soldier. You heard the wizard — there's something *nasty* down under there, and that stone's the cork holding it in. You don't pull a cork when you can't see the bottom of the bottle.

Lae'zel: *(seizing the word, returning it edged)* "A bottle." You reduce a weapon of war to tavern-drivel. Cockroaches, too, are content with the crumbs beneath the table.

Karlach: *(cheerful, not budging an inch)* And what? You'd cook a whole village of grannies for a shiny paperweight, so maybe we're both a bit predictable today, eh, Lae? *(to the pedestal, gently)* No offence, gorgeous.

Shadowheart: *(stepping into the middle, dry as flint)* So. Do we always haggle over stealing *this* loudly, or is today special? *(a hand up at each of them)* Lae'zel — set the word "requisition" down before you hurt someone with it. Karlach — stop defending the artifact. It's just a rock. *(then, to Gale, and the cold ledger is running behind her eyes even as her voice stays merely practical)* Gale — you said this is old-weave. In plain terms: what is a thing like that actually worth? In the right hands and the wrong hands? *(the question is a shade too level to be idle, and she knows he'll hear that)*

Gale: *(hands folding)* ...A great deal. I'll not insult anyone here by pretending otherwise — a knot of bound old-weave that size could *settle* a considerable share of my own more pressing difficulties, and I am the last man here entitled to pretend I hadn't noticed.

Lae'zel: *(seizing it, flat and immediate)* Then we are agreed. Even the wizard would profit — take it, and end this.

Gale: *(a short, pained breath)* We are agreed on *nothing*, and you have heard the exact opposite of what I said. *(steadier now, because this part he is sure of)* A thing worth stealing is, nine times in ten, not worth the trouble it could bring down on our heads, much less this whole region. To weigh one's benefit against a whole region's ruin is not, I'm afraid, a close accounting. *(Gale's certainty thins; he covers it the way he always does, with a lighter tone)* Besides, I have every confidence the good people I travel with would rather a less *incendiary* remedy for my own predicament well in hand, right? *(the smile arrives half a beat late)*

Narrator: *No one answers him quickly enough. The pause runs a beat too long to be kindness — the kind of silence a whole room feels.*

Gale: *(echoing)* Right?

Prue: *(mishearing the heat entirely, thrilled)* Oh, you've all taken such a shine to her! Here — let me fetch her down, you can have a proper hold, feel how warm she could—

(She reaches for the pedestal.)

Karlach: *(a gentle lunge, both hands out)* No — no no no, she's — she's grand right where she is, Prue! Perfect. Don't trouble yourself. Wouldn't want anyone to... *drop* her. *(a look that sweeps the whole party)* Would we?

Narrator: *The artifact stands in front of you on the pedestal, within arm's reach. Whatever it keeps down has waited sixty years. It can wait a moment more. Or are you willing to take this*

chance of taking Selûne a peg down or two along with her followers for your Lady Shar? The opportunity seems too perfect.

[Perception] VS 15 — success

Lae'zel: *(mid-breath — and then still; her head turns, and her blade is a hand's width clear of the sheath before anyone has seen her move)* Silence. *(low, and certain)* Someone stands at that door, and wishes very much that we did not know it.

Narrator: *You pause to listen. Beneath all the noise: a boot-scuff on the threshold stone, cloth dragged soft can be heard outside the front door of the annex — someone very close, and very quiet, lies in wait outside. For one more breath, it is yours to spend. The fate of Greenharrow could very well be in your hands. Lady Shar is watching.*

Shadowheart — (choose one)

1. **[Persuasion] VS 12** — "Enough. We're guests, not grave-robbers, and I won't have us remembered as the second. Hands where I can see them. We walk."
2. **[Persuasion] VS 12** — *Talk everyone down* **[Deception] VS 13** — **[Take the artifact.]**
3. **[Turn to the door — call out whoever's there.]** *The presence, made, breaks and runs — the party can give chase and take the confrontation on their own terms. The one chance to catch the thieves red-handed.*
4. *(Say nothing. Let the others decide.)*

Had no one heard the door — had that Perception check failed — Shadowheart would never be handed the choice to turn to the door at all. → see Branch D.

BRANCH A:

[Persuasion] VS 12 — success

Shadowheart: Enough, *(the room folds to her)* We're guests, not grave-robbers — and I won't have us remembered as the second. *(a glance that lands on each of them)* Hands where I can see them. We walk.

Karlach: *(all the fight going out of her in one breath, grinning)* That's — yeah. *That. (to Shadowheart, meaning it)* Knew there was a reason we let you do the talking. *(to the pedestal, softer)* Sorry, gorgeous. You're staying put. Best offer you'll get all week.

Lae'zel: *(a beat; the doctrine closes over the want, clean)* ...Tsk. The zaith'isk purifies; Vlaakith provides. This is scenery. *(she turns from the pedestal, parade-ground, and does not look at it again)* **[Karlach +1, Lae'zel +1]**

Gale: *(something in him eases)* I'll admit I wasn't certain which way this would go. I find myself more relieved that we all appealed to our better natures. *(lighter, but the warmth beneath it is real, and pointed)* Because a company that leaves a village defenseless to gods-knows-what just to suit their own interests... is precisely the company a man in my particular predicament would very much not like to be in. *(a small nod to the moment)* Shall we? Before the good woman offers us the pedestal as well.

Prue: *(bustling, delighted, understanding none of it)* Off already? Not without your tea and a bit of seedcake for the road! *(pressing warm parcels into your hands)* Take the moon's road, dearie, and mind the wolves past the mill. Do tell all folk — Greenharrow keeps well!

Narrator: *The stone hums on behind you, and though you will never feel it, a mile of quiet farmland lets out a breath and settles back to sleep, uncracked. You wanted it. You could've pleased Lady Shar by desecrating one of Selûne's shrines. And yet... you didn't. You walked instead out with your hands full of seedcake. The wanting comes too — patient, unspent — but tonight, for once, it walks a step behind. You can only hope Lady Shar doesn't hold this against you as you try to regain her favor.*

Aftermath. Nothing is taken; the wound stays asleep; Greenharrow lives another day. The only thread left hanging is the pair who never got their opening — a patient, professional interest that watched the shrine all evening and melted into the dusk when the party stayed alert. They do not forget an uncollected score.

(Later that night, at camp) **Karlach:** *(turning the little moon-charm Prue pressed on her)* Funny. We walked out with less than we could've, and I feel heavier in the good way. *(quieter)* ... Whoever was at that door, though. Bolted and ran the second we clocked 'em. That's not some chancer — that's someone who wanted that fancy stone and knew exactly what it was. Keep your blade where you can reach it, yeah?

BRANCH B:

[Persuasion] VS 12 — success

Narrator: *You argued them down. The warrior's requisition and the wizard's hunger you named aloud and shamed quiet — and the tiefling's refusal... you simply outlasted. And now the room is yours, and the pedestal lies open to you, and no one is watching.*

[Deception] VS 13 — success

Shadowheart: *(evenly, without heat, the way she does everything that costs)* Prue. The kettle — I think it's caught. *(the old woman turns; the ward-stone leaves the pedestal and is gone under a cloak in the time it takes a heart to beat once)*

Narrator: *The hum stops. The annex is suddenly, enormously quiet — and in the quiet, very far off, you hear something vast turn over, and begin, without any hurry at all, to wake. Not only do you hear it, you feel it.*

Karlach: *(the smile falling off her face like a dropped plate)* ...Shadowheart. Shadowheart, look at me. Put it back. Put it back right now, and we pretend — *(her voice cracks toward something younger)* — I've heard, back in the hells, what happens to a place like Greenharrow when something this valuable leaves. Don't do this. Not you.

Shadowheart: *(she meets Karlach's eyes and reaches for the acolyte's smile — practiced, weightless)* It's a *hamlet*, Karlach. Not a city. That's rather the whole point of the arithmetic, if you'd let me finish doing it. *(a light turn of the wrist)* The Moonmaiden's hoarded her treasures for sixty years — she can be generous the once. And I've somewhere a great deal more important to be than a widow's larder... or exploded by Gale. *(Karlach's face; Shadowheart looks away from it)* Oh, don't. You'll spoil the one genuinely useful thing about me — that I can make these sort of decisions, and you can't. *(already turning, brisk)*

Lae'zel: *(cold approval, colder for how little it costs her)* So. The leader understands requisition after all. *(a single nod)* The wolf does not beg the lamb's pardon for its teeth. You are harder than you play at, Shadowheart — I approve.

Gale: *(he opens his mouth — closes it again)* I— *(a breath; held very level)* I am going to say nothing. I want that *noted*. That I said nothing, and what it cost me to say it. ... We should be gone before she turns round.

Prue: *(turning back, the kettle innocent in her hand)* Caught? No, dearie, she's singing fine as — *(her eyes go to the empty pedestal; something in her face simply doesn't understand)* Oh. Oh, where's she — where's my girl? Where's she gone? She was just— *(she looks at each of your faces, still trusting, still not seeing it)*

Narrator: *No one answers her. You have what you came for, and a piece of yourself is already rehearsing the reasons. The ward-stone lies in your pack next to the astral prism. The wound is awake. The old woman looks at the four of you as though one of you will explain where her whole world went. Lady Shar would be proud. [Karlach -10 · Gale -5 · Lae'zel +1]*

Aftermath. The theft is a fuse, not a footnote. Within nights a child three doors from Prue's wakes screaming about a grey man at the window and cannot be woken; the mill-keeper walks into the river certain it is a road home; and the bad-hearted things the stone kept off for sixty years find the gap where its hum used to be. You did not rob an old woman of a keepsake — you opened the hand. In Shadowheart's pack the silver light gutters and goes out, the relic dead-cold in the grip of, of all people, a daughter of the moon's rival; she feels it, and says nothing. The blight creeps out along the refugee road she meant to save time

for, and a Selûnite reckoning, when it comes, will have a witness — Prue, or a Greenharrow child, among the displaced.

(camp, later) **Karlach:** I've been trying to find the version of tonight where you're still someone I'd take a blade for. *(flat, no heat, which is worse)* Not finding it fast, Shadowheart. Fix that. While it's still fixable.

BRANCH C:

[Persuasion] VS 12 — failure

Shadowheart: Enough. We're guests, not grave-robbers, and I won't have us — *Lae'zel*. Lae'zel, do **not** —

Lae'zel: *(already moving; she does not argue, she executes)* Deliberation is a luxury of the unthreatened. *(the ward-stone is off the pedestal and in her fist before she finishes)*

Narrator: *The hum stops mid-note — and for one breath the floor goes wrong under every boot in the room, a lurch with no source, there and gone.*

Karlach: *(lunging, too late, hands grabbing air)* LAE'ZEL — put it — gods, put it *back*, put it back put it back —

Gale: *(flailing)* That — that is the precise course of action I expended considerable breath advising against, and I should like it *formally noted* that —

Lae'zel: *(cold, closing her hand around the ward-stone)* It is done. Recriminate on the march.

Prue: *(clapping, delighted, reading the scramble as sport)* Oh, careful, dears — she's slippery when she's excited! *(beaming)* But you've got her! There now — isn't she a wonder up close?

Shadowheart: *(rounding on Lae'zel)* Put. It. Down. You couldn't sit still for the length of *one conversation* — you've just cracked a sixty-year ward over a *hunch*.

Lae'zel: *(taking the word from her mouth and turning it back, edged)* "A hunch." The moon-priestess mourns turnip-farmers she would not remember past the next mile-marker. I have lifted a shield against the thing that eats minds. When the ghaik come whispering into your sleep, *istik*, you will wish you had thanked me.

Narrator: *The word "moon-priestess" lands somewhere it has no business landing. For half a second something behind your eyes goes very still. You do not correct it. Correcting it would cost more than letting it stand.*

Shadowheart: *(when she speaks it is flint — level, controlled, colder for how tightly it's held)* I don't want your shield, Lae'zel. I wanted us to walk out of here with clean hands — and not for the *virtue* of it. A party that robs shrines is a party the next door doesn't open for, and we have a long road still to walk. *(a beat)* You couldn't even give me that.

Karlach: *(stepping between them, and the anchor's voice cuts the noise dead)* STOP. All of you. *Stop. (pointing, low and furious)* There is a woman standing right there who does not yet know her entire life just walked out the door. So maybe we do the screaming *later*. Yeah?

Prue: *(the joy finally faltering)* ...Dears? Is — is everything quite right?

Shadowheart: *(she does not answer Prue, and she does not look at Lae'zel again. She turns — precise, unhurried— and makes for the dusk. Over her shoulder, flat and final)* We're done here. Do what you like with it. You always will anyway.

Narrator: *One by one they follow her out — Lae'zel with her prize, Gale with his silence, Karlach last of all, looking back once at the old woman she cannot help and the empty pedestal she couldn't save. The door swings shut on Prue's unanswered question. Whatever the four of you are now, you are it together, and you are it one stone the poorer, in the only ways that were ever going to count. [Karlach –10 · Gale –5]*

Aftermath. The ward's fall does to Greenharrow what a ward's fall does — the dreams, the grey men at the windows, the old rot creeping out along the refugee road. In Lae'zel's keeping the silver of the ward-stone goes cold and lightless; she calls it superstition, which somehow makes the dark of it colder. The party carries the fracture with them: Karlach's anger lands not only on Lae'zel but on Shadowheart who lost control of it. Shadowheart, who wanted so badly to walk out *clean*, has to live in the company that watched her fail to do so.

BRANCH D:

[Perception] VS 15 — failure.

A sound is heard at the front door. No one hears it. Lae'zel's head never turns; the boot-scuff at the threshold goes unmarked beneath four raised voices; no one calls the door. And so Shadowheart is never handed the choice to turn to door — she is now simply too distracted — creating the moment these mysterious rogues have been waiting for.

[Persuasion] VS 12 — failure

Shadowheart: For the *last* time, we are **not** —

Lae'zel: You have declared "the last time" on four occasions, moon-priestess. Your discipline is theatre.

Karlach: *(wading in, arms wide, herding them like geese)* Okay — OKAY — everybody, deep breath. Deep breath, everyone. Prue's got tea, nobody's touching the rock, we are simply — having a chat. A loud chat. About a rock. In a nice lady's house.

Gale: *(pitching over the din, to no one)* If I might reintroduce a *note of arcane precision* to the proceedings — the salient point that everyone appears to be —

Shadowheart: *(over him)* — Lae'zel, if you say "requisition" one more time —

Lae'zel: *(over her)* Requi—

Prue: *(to a knock none of you registered, delighted)* Oh — more visitors! Come in, come in, dears, it's a *busy* day for the old girl!

[Perception] VS 15 — failure.

Narrator: *Two travellers enter, one lifts a hand as if to wave hello, and a small enchantment slips loose of the gesture, soft as a thumb smoothing a crease. Prue's face opens like a window — old friends, of course — and she turns back to the four of you, warm and unwary, to share the joy of it. You do not see the second one move. You could not: the air around them lies flat and swallows every footfall before it lands. And you are not looking. You are so loud, and so utterly certain the only danger in this room is each other, that a hand you never mark closes on the ward-stone, lifts the ward-stone clean out of the pedestal, and folds it away. The hum stops. Two hooded backs are already through the door, and the door gives onto an empty lane.*

Karlach: *(trailing off mid-gesture)* ...Wait. Hang on. Why's it — why's it gone quiet?

Shadowheart: *(head turning, slow, dread arriving all at once)* ...The pedestal.

Lae'zel: *(already at the front door, blade half-drawn, hurled into an empty lane)* Gone. Two of them — south, and the very air closes behind them. *(a snarl of grudging assessment)* Trained. Disciplined. Human work, and better than your kind has any right to be. I did not hear them breathe.

Gale: *(crouching quick beside Prue, fingers reading the air a hand's breadth from her temple)* ...Oh. *Oh, no.* There's a Charm on her — a hasty one. They reached into this poor woman's *head* and made sure she didn't draw any attention to them. *(rising, appalled)* Whoever they were, they were not amateurs. And they left in a hurry.

[Perception / Investigation] VS 13 — success

Narrator: *There, by the door-jamb, dropped in the rogue's hurry: a courier's cargo-tag — leather and brass, stamped with a single coiled serpent. It must've fallen when the stone went into the thief's cloak.*

Karlach: *(turning it over)* ...Huh. I've seen a mark like that. Baldur's Gate — the arms crowd, the ones who smile while they count your teeth. *(a frown)* Bad news with a smile. Can't put a name to it, though. Been too long, and too far.

[History] VS 10 — success

Gale: The coiled serpent — that's the Black Network. The *Zhentarim*. Smugglers, couriers, killers-for-coin, and no loyalty that outlasts the payment. *(a beat, cold)* Which raises the far worse question of who is *paying* them to lift a Selûnite ward-stone off a pedestal in the middle of nowhere. But that's a thread for a darker campfire than this one.

Prue: *(the charm still warm on her, turning from the door without a shadow of alarm)* ...Did your nice friends have to rush off, then? *(a small, contented laugh)* Didn't even stop for a seedcake.

Narrator: *You were not outfought. You were not even outrun. You drowned your own ears, and someone patient walked in through the din and lifted the ward-stone from under your nose. The ward-stone is going south in a stranger's pack, toward whatever coin commissioned it, and with every mile it goes the wound it has kept shut will soon wake.*

Aftermath. Greenharrow dies the same death by a worse hand — the dreams, the grey men, the rot on the road — and this time you did not even *choose* it. The Black Network does what it always does: the ward-stone goes up the smuggling line, and the buyer at the top of that line has been paying Zhentarim couriers to run stranger cargo than a moon-relic. What the Absolute cult wants with such a relic that *turns aside what creeps into sleeping heads* is not a trophy — it is an obstacle to be removed, or a lock to be studied. The small ward-stone you let fall is a quiet rhyme with far greater consequences yet to come that you have yet to understand. You will see the ward-stone again and you will remember that you failed Greenharrow the first time. Will you fail the next time?

Companion voices per Act-1 characterization (Shadowheart / Lae'zel / Karlach / Gale). Original pastiche; unaffiliated with Larian Studios and Wizards of the Coast.